

## AND THE WINNER IS ...

Who got Oscared? And what were they thinking when they decided to wear that? Coverage straight from the edge of the red carpet.

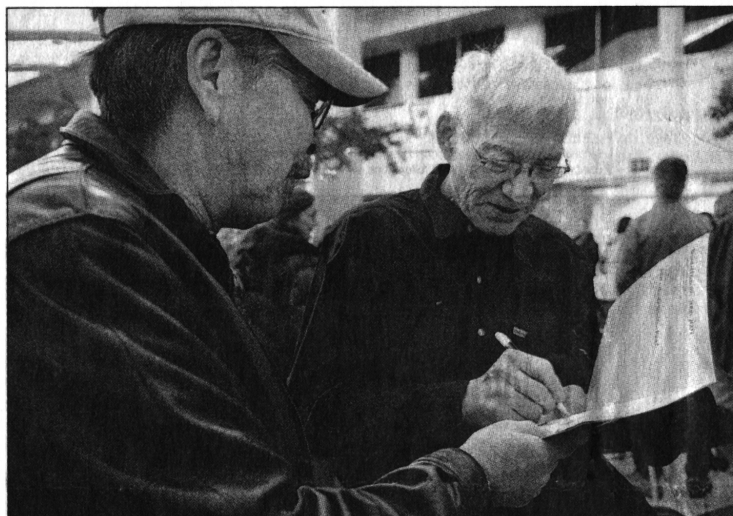
Monday in Life & Change

# SPORTS

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★ SUNDAY, FEBRUARY 25, 2007

## Attla sets tone for march into Alaska hall of fame



STEPHEN NOWERS / Anchorage Daily News

Sprint musher George Attla signs Victor Nicholas' program after a ceremony Friday celebrating the inaugural Alaska Sports Hall of Fame class. Attla, Susan Butcher, Scott Gomez, Tommy Moe and Kristen Thorsness were honored for their achievements.

■ **STANDING OVATION:** Crowd shows respect for sprint musher.

By **MELISSA DeVAUGHN**  
Anchorage Daily News

The standing ovation for George Attla came fast and purposefully, lasting minutes. It was the kind of ovation that comes from the heart — not an obligatory nod of approval but a gesture of true respect and warmth.

Before announcer Rick Mystrom had finished reading Attla's name as recipient of one of the eight awards given the inaugural class of the Alaska Sports Hall of Fame on Friday night, the crowd was on its feet.

"That shows the love that the people of Alaska have for you, George," Mystrom said, as the applause faded and people sat down.

Attla, the winningest sprint musher Alaska has ever known and the inspiration behind the movie, "Spirit of the Wind," was one of five athletes, two mo-

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### Alaska Sports Hall of Fame

#### PEOPLE

- **GEORGE ATTLA**, world-champion sprint musher, 10-time Fur Rondy and eight-time North American champion
- **SUSAN BUTCHER**, Iditarod musher, four-time champion
- **SCOTT GOMEZ**, NHL hockey player with New Jersey Devils who's won the Stanley Cup twice
- **TOMMY MOE**, Olympic gold-medal winning downhill skier
- **KRISTEN THORSNESS**, Olympic gold-medal winning rower

#### MOMENTS

- **FIRST ASCENT OF MOUNT MCKINLEY** in 1913, by Walter Harper, Harry Karstens, Hudson Stuck and Robert Tatum
- **LIBBY RIDDLES' BRAVE BATTLE** against a ground blizzard to become the first woman to win the Iditarod in 1985

#### EVENT

- **IDITAROD TRAIL SLED DOG RACE**, which has become an Alaska tradition and is famous worldwide



STEPHEN NOWERS / Anchorage Daily News

Olympian Tommy Moe holds up his Alaska Sports Hall of Fame award during Friday's induction ceremony. Moe's victory over Norway's Kjetil Andre Aamodt at the 1994 Winter Olympics in Lillehammer, Norway, was by 0.04 seconds, the closest alpine race in Olympic history.

# HALL: Eight awards given in inaugural event

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ments and one event honored as the Alaska Sports Hall of Fame was enshrined.

The project is a dream finally realized by one of Anchorage's own well-known athletes, runner Harlow Robinson.

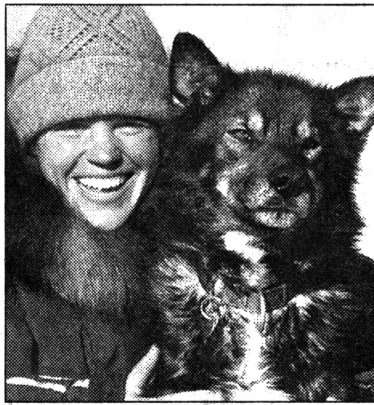
"I've been wanting to do this since I was a little kid," said Robinson, 40, who grew up around mountaineers and is himself an accomplished mountain runner who's twice won the challenging Crow Pass Crossing.

"Now that I've grown up and know what sports have done for me, I just decided it was time," he said. "It was a matter of getting to the age where I thought, 'Why not me?'"

The Friday night event, with a full crowd at the Conoco Phillips atrium, brought together a diverse and deserving group of athletes, outdoors men and women and their families.

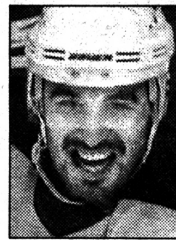
Rower Kristen Thorsness, who in 1984 became the first Alaskan to win an Olympic gold medal, sat beside Dave Monson, accepting the honor on behalf of his wife, Susan Butcher, honored posthumously for her dominance of the Iditarod during the 1980s.

The family of current NHL hockey standout Scott Gomez was seated near the families of Harry Karstens and Walter Harper, two of the four men whose first ascent of Denali in 1913 was recognized as one of the best Alaska sports moments.



JIM LAVRAKAS / Daily News archive 1986

Susan Butcher won the Iditarod for the first time in 1986 and then went on to win three more.



Gomez



Thorsness

"I was rendered speechless," Thorsness said, upon hearing she had been selected for the honor a few weeks ago. "To just row a boat, and be with people like Libby Riddles (honored for her 1985 Iditarod victory, making her the first woman to win) and George and Susan?"

"To be included in this class is a tremendous honor," she said.

Robinson said he hopes this year's event is a catalyst for

## online

■ **FIRST CLASS:** For more details about the inaugural inductees, a list of other nominees and information about the Alaska Sports Hall of Fame, [00f3e34.netsolhost.com/inductees.html](http://00f3e34.netsolhost.com/inductees.html)

future years. He even hopes to find a permanent home for the Hall of Fame, setting down roots so visitors can better see and appreciate the accomplishments of the inductees.

The Alaska Sports Hall of Fame formed as a nonprofit in 2004, but just this year finalized its first honorees after votes by the public and a review panel. Robinson wanted these first recipients, in particular, to represent a cross-section of Alaskans and sports.

"There's the Golden Book, ASAA (Alaska School Activities Association) Hall of Fame, the Seawolves Hall of Fame," Robinson said. "I wanted this to be something bigger than putting a plaque on the wall. I wanted it to include all Alaskans."

To that end, Friday's event was a success. Five people, two moments and one event were honored, covering the sports of sprint and distance mushing, mountaineering, rowing, downhill skiing and hockey.

Tommy Moe's 1994 gold-medal winning Olympic downhill race received recognition, and the usually casual Moe was there to accept his award, dressed in a dark suit and white shirt that made him look more

businessman than ski racer.

After the audience watched footage on a large screen showing Moe's medal-winning run during the Lillehammer, Norway, Winter Games, Moe, like the others, had a few moments to speak.

"For me, it was either I was going to win, or I was going to crash," he said to appreciative laughter. "Here's to more Olympians from Alaska in the future."

The sole winner in the event category was the Iditarod Trail Sled Dog Race, which started in 1973. Back then, the Iditarod seemed to be a small race with no real future.

But that did not happen.

"None of us really thought it would go far except two people," said Iditarod Board of Directors president Richard Burmeister, accepting the award. "Joe Redington and Dorothy Page. ... I wish Joe was here and Dorothy was here today to accept this because there'd be a smile on their face, saying, 'I told you so.'"

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